

Carl Peters
Berlin Conference of 1884
Scramble for Africa

The late 19th century has been a time of intense competition among European powers for territorial acquisition in Africa, driven by economic and political motives. Germany first rose to power after the Holy Roman Empire's dissolution in 1817, and with our unification in 1871, we entered the race later than bygone powers of Britain, France, and Belgium. Under leaders such as myself, Carl Peters, and Chancellor Otto von Bismarck, Germany seeks to quickly secure its position by negotiating treaties with local African rulers, establishing protectorates, and demonstrating effective occupation. This era, known as the "Scramble for Africa," will be full of rapid territorial claims, discovery of valuable resources, growing industrial demands, and the strategic desire to control trade routes.

The Berlin Conference was convened to bring order and peace to this chaotic competition, prevent conflicts among European nations, and set the stage for Germany's colonial ambitions to flourish. The German Empire recognizes the importance of the current negotiations, and so we called the Berlin Conference to govern it. These discussions represent a critical moment to address European expansion in Africa in a structured and fair manner. Germany, as a rising industrial and imperial power, seeks to establish its rightful place on the global stage, while promoting international cooperation and stability.

As an experienced explorer, I am familiar with the complexities of expansion. And as Reichskommissar of German East Africa, I will advocate for a fair and systematic approach to the division of African territories to avoid conflicts among European powers. Germany supports the following key principles:

1. Effective Occupation: A power claiming a territory must demonstrate effective control and governance to legitimize its claim. This ensures that colonial endeavors are more than nominal declarations. Additionally, this will empower German colonial officials to successfully administer their territories.

2. Free Trade: Germany supports open trade along Africa's major rivers, particularly the Congo and Niger, to promote economic opportunities for all participating nations.

3. Abolition of the Slave Trade: Germany supports the elimination of the inhumane slave trade, and emphasizes the importance of highlighting humanitarian and civilizing missions.

Germany's vision for Africa is one of modernization and progress. By introducing infrastructure, education, and economic development, Germany wants to bring the benefits of European civilization to African territories. This attempt, however, must be conducted with respect to the boundaries and agreements established during this conference.

Germany and I urge all delegates to approach the division of Africa with a spirit of diplomacy and pragmatism: The Berlin Conference must prioritize the prevention of inter-European conflict while ensuring that Africa's resources are utilized responsibly. Germany is prepared to cooperate and negotiate in good faith to achieve these goals. Germany stands ready to contribute to the successful outcome of this historic conference. By working together, we can lead a new era of European collaboration and prosperity in Africa.

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From Background Guide:

Scramble for Africa - The period of intense competition among European nations to claim African territories in the late 19th century, driven by a desire for resources and strategic control.

2. Berlin Conference (1884-1885) - A meeting where European powers agreed on rules for the colonization and division of Africa, aiming to avoid conflict among European nations during the "Scramble for Africa."

3. Plenipotentiaries - A person, usually a diplomat, who has the complete authority to take independent action on behalf of their nation.

4. Colonialism - The policy or practice of acquiring control over another country, occupying it with settlers, and exploiting it economically. In Africa, European colonialism reshaped societies, economies, and political boundaries.

5. Spheres of Influence - Areas where one country has dominant control or influence over others, often economically or politically, without formal ownership. European countries established these in Africa to assert their interests.

6. Industrial Revolution - A period of rapid industrial growth in Europe (18th to 19th centuries) that created high demand for raw materials and markets, driving European nations to seek colonies in Africa and elsewhere.

7. Artificial Borders - Boundaries created by European powers at the Berlin Conference without regard for the cultural, ethnic, or geographic realities of African societies. These borders often forced diverse groups into single colonies, leading to lasting conflicts.